

Handout: *Paley's Watchmaker Argument & Hume's Critique*

I. The Problem of Design in Nature

At the heart of both Paley and Hume lies a shared philosophical problem:

How should we explain the apparent order, complexity, and purposiveness of the natural world?

- The world appears **structured**, **law-governed**, and **teleological** (goal-directed).
 - Organisms exhibit **functional organization** (e.g., eyes for seeing, hearts for pumping).
 - This raises a classical question in **natural theology**:
 - *Is this order best explained by intelligent design (God), or can it arise through non-intentional processes?*
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II. Paley: The Argument from Design (The Watchmaker Analogy)

A. Framing the Problem

Paley begins with an intuitive contrast:

- A **stone** might plausibly be explained as having “always been there.”
- A **watch**, however, cannot be explained this way.

The **problem**:

Why do we treat these objects differently?

B. Paley's Solution: Inference to Design

Key Insight

The difference lies in **contrivance**—the arrangement of parts for a purpose.

- The watch exhibits:
 - **Complex organization**
 - **Interdependence of parts**
 - **Goal-directed functioning** (telling time)

Therefore, it must have had a **designer**

C. Structure of the Argument

1. Observation of Mechanism

- Parts are **finely tuned** and **precisely arranged**.
- If parts were altered, the function would fail.

2. Inference to Intelligence

- Such arrangement implies:
 - **Intentional planning**
 - **Knowledge of ends and means**

3. Conclusion

- Therefore, the watch has a **maker**.
 - By analogy, so too does **nature**.
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D. Strengthening the Argument (Paley's Replies to Objections)

Paley anticipates and dismisses several objections:

1. Ignorance of the Designer

- Even if we've never seen a watch made:
 - This does not undermine the inference to design.

2. Imperfection

- A malfunctioning watch still implies a designer.

- **Design ≠ perfection**

3. Unknown Parts

- Even if some parts' functions are unclear:
 - The overall **systemic purposiveness** remains.

4. Chance

- Rejects the idea that the watch is a random configuration:
 - Probability cannot account for **functional complexity**.

5. Laws of Nature

- Laws are not causes:
 - They presuppose an **agent or power**

E. Application to Nature

Paley's crucial move:

"Every indication of contrivance... exists in the works of nature"

- Nature exhibits:
 - Greater **complexity**
 - Greater **variety**
 - Greater **subtlety** than artifacts

Conclusion

- Therefore:
 - Nature → like a watch
 - Watch → requires a designer
 - **Nature → requires a divine designer (God)**

F. Philosophical Significance

- This is an **a posteriori argument**:
 - Based on empirical observation

- It relies on **analogical reasoning**:
 - Artifact : designer :: nature : God
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III. Hume: A Critique of the Design Argument

A. The Problem with Paley's Reasoning

Hume (through Philo) challenges the **strength of the analogy**:

The argument depends entirely on whether the universe is sufficiently like a machine.

B. Core Critique: Weak Analogy

1. Principle of Empirical Reasoning

- We infer causes from effects only when:
 - We have **repeated experience** of their conjunction 😊.

Examples:

- Houses → builders
- Watches → watchmakers

2. The Problem

- We have **no experience** of:
 - Universe-making
- Therefore:
 - The analogy is **weak and speculative**

At best, the design argument yields a “*guess*” or “*conjecture*”

C. Disanalogy Between Universe and Artifacts

- The universe is:
 - **Unique**

- **Infinite (or vast)**
- **Organic rather than mechanical?**

Key question:

- Why assume the universe is like a **machine**, rather than:
 - A plant?
 - An organism?
 - Something entirely unknown?

D. The Fallacy of Composition

Hume presses a crucial point:

You cannot infer properties of the whole from parts.

- Just because:
 - Some **parts of nature** involve design (human artifacts),
- It does not follow that:
 - The **entire universe** is designed.

E. Alternative Explanations

Hume opens the door to competing hypotheses:

- Order may arise from:
 - **Matter itself**
 - Unknown natural principles
- The universe could be:
 - The result of **trial and error**
 - One of many failed worlds
 - Produced by **multiple gods**

F. Critique of Anthropomorphism

Paley's argument implies:

- God is like a **human mind**

Hume finds this deeply problematic:

- Why assume:
 - A **human-like intelligence?**
 - This reflects:
 - **Anthropocentric bias**
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G. Limits on Theological Conclusions

Even if design were granted:

What can we infer about God?

Hume argues: **very little**

- Not:
 - Infinity
 - Perfection
 - Unity

Instead, the designer could be:

- Finite
 - Imperfect
 - Multiple
 - Even incompetent
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H. The Problem of Evil (Implicit)

- The world contains:
 - Disorder, suffering, imperfection

If effects resemble causes:

- Then the designer may be:
 - **Imperfect or morally flawed**
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I. Epistemological Skepticism

Hume's deeper point:

Human reason is too limited to infer the origin of the universe.

- We observe:
 - Only a **tiny portion** of reality
 - Therefore:
 - Any metaphysical conclusion is **radically underdetermined**
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